Institution: Museum of Fine Arts, Boston
Registration Number: 63.952
Beazley Archive Number: 350462
Fabric: Athenian, black-figure
Shape: Amphorae, Type A
Attribution: *close to* Exekias, Beazley; potted by Exekias, Bloesch
Date: Archaic Period; ~540–530 BCE
Dimensions: H. 51.4 cm; D. 33 cm
Provenance: Purchased from Henry Lillie Pierce Residuary Fund and Bartlett Collection, 1963

Fabric, Technique, Shape & Condition
Attic black-figure panel amphora. Type A, made from characteristic orange-red Attic clay.[1] Figures rendered in black slip on reserved ground with incised interior details; added white and red-purple slip are used selectively for decorative features (e.g. white for Helen's skin and eyes, red-purple for male hair and Dionysus' wreath). Handles are flanged and decorated. The foot is in two degrees with rays above. The vessel is largely intact, with some repairs visible on the neck and lip. An oval misfire spot in red on panel B has been covered with a modern gray varnish. Missing fragments are restored in colour-matched plaster; lost decorative elements remain unpainted.
Iconography The handles are decorated with an ivy pattern. Both panels on the body of the vessel are surmounted by a palmette-lotus chain and framed with two bands of glaze lines below. Painted inscriptions identify the principal figures on both panels.

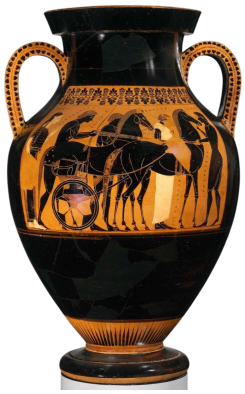

Fig. 1. Close to Exekias, *Two-Handled Jar (Amphora) with Dionysos in a Vineyard*, Side A: The Dioskouroi harness a biga. Greek, Archaic period, ca. 540–530 BCE. Ceramic, black-figure. Image: Museum of Fine Arts, Boston.

Panel A depicts the harnessing of the Dioskouroi's chariot (Fig.1). Polydeukes steadies the vehicle while holding the reins and a goad. Eurylochos controls the near horse by rein and chest strap while Aischines manages the off horse. Kastor is standing to the right in a long chiton. Helen, raises her hand in farewell to the far left of panel A. The composition distributes action across multiple figures, articulating a moment of imminent departure within a spatially coherent arrangement.[2]

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[1]Classical Art Research Centre, University of Oxford. "Amphorae." *Introduction to Greek Pottery*. Accessed April 6, 2026. https://www.carc.ox.ac.uk/carc/resources/Introduction-to-Greek-Pottery/Shapes/Amphorae.
"Amphorae." *Introduction to Greek Pottery*. Accessed April 6, 2026. https://www.carc.ox.ac.uk/carc/resources/Introduction-to-Greek-Pottery/Shapes/Amphorae.

[2] *Corpus Vasorum Antiquorum*: United States, fasc. 14, *Boston, Museum of Fine Arts*, fasc. 1 (Cambridge, MA: Archaeological Institute of America, 1973), 9–10, fig. 14, pl. 634, 12.1–3.

Fig. 2. Close to Exekias, *Two-Handled Jar (Amphora) with Dionysos in a Vineyard*, ca. 540–530 BCE. Ceramic, black-figure. Museum of Fine Arts, Boston, 1963.952. Image: Museum of Fine Arts, Boston.

Panel B depicts Dionysus, ivy-wreathed, and wearing a chiton, sitting on a folding stool with feline legs (Fig.2). He holds a kantharos and a trailing ivy branch. A grapevine rises from the ground and forms an overhead arbour populated by twelve diminutive satyrs, who climb, swing, and recline among its tendrils. The details of grapes and baskets are rendered with incision. Dionysus is identified by inscription; the satyrs are unlabelled.

Attribution & Dating The vessel is attributed as close to Exekias, with the potting independently assigned to Exekias by Bloesch, suggesting production within his workshop.[3] The attribution is supported by several characteristic features of Exekias' mature work including the controlled and balanced composition, clarity and monumentality of individual figures, and the precise use of articulate anatomy and drapery.[4] On panel A, the measured spacing of figures and the coordination of gestures across the chariot group reflect compositional strategies closely associated with Exekias. Comparable organisation of figural action appears on the Exekias amphora at the Vatican (Achilles and Ajax), where gesture and spatial balance similarly structure the scene (Fig.3).[5]

On panel B, the integration of ornament and figural scene with the vine structures organising the movement of the satyrs also parallels Exekias' approaches to structuring pictorial space through decorative systems.[6] At the same time, the handling of secondary figures and incisions are slightly less precise than in securely attributed works by Exekias, supporting attribution to a painter working in his immediate circle rather than Exekias himself.[7] The vessel is therefore placed within the later phase of Exekias' activity, approximately between 540-530 BCE.

Fig. 3. Exekias, *Amphora with Ajax and Achilles Playing a Board Game*, later 6th century BCE. Attic black-figure, Type A; H.

[3] *Corpus Vasorum Antiquorum*, 1973.
[4] J. D. Beazley. "Exekias." In *The Development of the Attic Black-Figure, Revised Edition*, DGO-Digital original, 1. University of California Press, 2023.
[5] J. D. Beazley. "Exekias.", 2023.
[6] Ibid.
[7] *Corpus Vasorum Antiquorum*, 1973.

61 cm. Vatican City, Vatican Museums. Left: Side A, Ajax and Achilles playing a board game. Right: Side B, Dioskouroi returning home. Photographs: J. Boardman, *La céramique antique* (left); M. Tiverios, *Elliniki Techni* (right). Images via Classical Art Research Centre, University of Oxford.

Works Cited

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